

Price watch

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Hybrids or Good old Laptops?

Take a step back and analyse the hype. Should you really go gaga over hybrid laptops?

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The writing's on the wall for quite some time. Smartphones and tablets are the new kings of the consumer tech world, while traditional laptops are getting filed in the "not so cool" cabinet. It's a post-PC world, smart is sexy, yada yada yada. To reverse the trend of dipping laptop sales, OEMs are blending them with "desirable" tablet features, hoping against hope you'd opt for it rather than spend your money on a touch-only slate sans keyboard.

After all, why not? Hybrids are the stuff of industrial designers', marketers' and consumers' combined wet dreams. Epic drool worthy stuff. An evolutionary convergence of two product lines that seem a match made in tech heaven. What's not to like? Hey, don't give me dirty looks, I'm all for them – All Day I Dream About Gadgets, too. But I won't go to a store and buy one without thinking of the following things first:

Am I confused?

Believe it or not, it's a very important question. With hybrids launching all around, it's difficult not to contemplate purchasing one. But my advice to you in this case is something I observed very clearly about the so-called phablets. A smartphone ends at about 5-inches and a tablet starts at 7-inches – it is known. Anything in between is neither this or that (although it promises to be both). It's for



consumers who are either ill-informed or a bit confused over what they want from a device, at least as far as phablets are concerned. Sure, it reduces the number of devices you have to carry, but it also involves a steep learning curve and the potential to make you look ridiculous – try speaking on a 7-inch phablet held against your ear or typing on it single-handedly.

It's the same with hybrids and 2-in-1 laptops, at the moment. Everyone's making a lot of noise about them, trying hard to out-innovate the competition, and ensure their hybrid is filled with features (doesn't matter if some of them are ridiculous) so that customers are bedazzled by their capabilities. It seems great trying to justify these features at the moment of purchase, but as the novelty value of the device and the experience fades, I've seen regret replace exuberance far too many times. Let that not be your hybrid purchase story. Therefore, re-evaluate

whether you definitely need all the Optimus Prime-esque features advertised for the hybrid you wish to buy for yourself or gift to someone.

What's wrong with laptops and tablets being separate?

Seriously, why do they need to be moulded into one? This point becomes even more important when you consider the following. Cheap hybrids or 2-in-1 laptops are mostly just tablets with extended keyboards (and battery) – you can't really create much on them, can you now? They're consumption devices. On the flip side, powerful hybrids are more laptops than the slim, trim, ergonomic and easy-to-carry tablets they (also) claim to be – you can't really use it as a tablet when it comes with a 13 / 14 or 15-inch screen now, can you? If that's the case, conventional wisdom needs to be challenged or even redefined. Plus all great hybrids are